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A magazine about the Arashan breed, people and the future

ARASHAN

5 years later: opinion of the co-developer



A hobby for real men

The Arashan Phenomenon

Selective breeding or business?

A nomadic legacy



Kochkor “Lord” — live weight 236 kg

Table of Contents

2	From the Editor
4	The history of the Arashan breed
6	Arashan sheep: breeding or business?
9	Sheep are the best asset
12	The Arashan Phenomenon
15	A Model Sheep Farm
18	The Best is Yet to Come
21	Five Years Later
26	Arashan: A Dual Focus on Breeding and Meat Production
30	Breeding Built on Strong Genetics
34	Sheep Have a Way of Softening the Heart
38	A Hobby for Real Men
42	A Nomadic Legacy
46	One Ram makes a Big Difference
49	Arashan: A Breed with Unique Characteristics
52	Arashan Sheep: Prospects for the European Market
55	A Reproductive Biotechnology Laboratory
58	Karakol: A Brotherhood Tested by Time
61	Selection and Mating: The Foundation of Breeding Work
65	Photo Report: Events of the Year
72	Photo Gallery

Kyrgyz Public Association
of Sheep Breeders

Instagram

YouTube

From the Editor

Dear sheep breeders, breeding specialists,
and everyone interested in the Arashan breed,

Greetings from sunny Kyrgyzstan!
Welcome to the inaugural issue of ARASHAN, a magazine dedicated to the Kyrgyz Arashan sheep breed, the people who breed and improve it, and the development of sheep farming as a whole.
We created this magazine as a professional platform for sharing experience, knowledge, and ideas. It highlights the people behind the industry, showcases the results of selective breeding, introduces readers to leading farms, and opens up new opportunities for cooperation both within Kyrgyzstan and internationally. The magazine is published in Russian and English. The interviews are accompanied by a video tour of the featured farm, accessible via a QR code on the corresponding page.
For us, ARASHAN is more than a magazine. It is an opportunity to bring together people who care about the future of sheep farming, create a space for professional dialogue, and contribute to the growth of the industry.

With respect,
Sardarbek Bagishbekov
Editor, ARASHAN



About the Editor

Sardarbek Bagishbekov is a farmer, owner of a sheep-breeding farm, legal counsel to the Kyrgyz Arashan Sheep Breeders Association, and author of a blog on farming. Sardarbek sees pedigree sheep breeding as a promising area for the development of Kyrgyzstan's agricultural sector. The creation of ARASHAN magazine was his initiative, aimed at bringing sheep breeders together, sharing professional knowledge, and strengthening cooperation with colleagues abroad. The magazine's primary mission is to promote pedigree sheep breeding in Kyrgyzstan, raise awareness of the Arashan breed, and help it gain international recognition.

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Kyrgyz Public Association of Sheep Breeders

The Kyrgyz Public Association of Sheep Breeders specializing in the Arashan meat-and-fat sheep breed is a non-governmental, nonprofit organization established in 2019 at the initiative of sheep breeders in the Kyrgyz Republic.

Membership
Membership in the Association is open to individuals who own Arashan sheep that have undergone performance evaluation and received an official pedigree certificate issued by the Association, share its goals and objectives, pay membership dues, and actively participate in the organization's work.

Mission
To develop, promote, and protect the new Kyrgyz Arashan meat-and-fat sheep breed; improve breeding and selection practices; and advance the interests of the breed and Arashan breeders at both the national and international levels.

The Arashan Breed
Arashan is a Kyrgyz meat-and-fat sheep breed officially registered on April 15, 2021, under Order No. 110 of the Minister of Agriculture, Water Resources, and Regional Development of the Kyrgyz Republic. Patent No. 66, recognizing the breed as a breeding achievement, was issued to the Kyrgyz Public Association of Sheep Breeders on August 30, 2023.

Key Breed Characteristics
- Excellent meat and fat production qualities
- A large fat tail
- High growth and development rates
- Strong adaptability to conditions ranging from high-mountain regions to valley steppes

Live Weight of Mature Animals
- Breeding rams, 3 years and older: 140–210 kg (309–463 lb)
- Ewes, 3 years and older: 90–150 kg (198–331 lb)

Breed Characteristics
Arashan sheep are distinguished by their large size and well-proportioned conformation. They have large heads, deep chests, and straight backs and rumps. Their bodies are broad, and their legs are straight and set widely apart. The breed is characterized by high live weight, early maturity, well-developed fat tails, and strong adaptability to pasture-based management.

Presentation video about Arashan sheep

The history of the Arashan breed

"The Arashan breed is the result of decades of dedicated work by passionate sheep farmers who relied on years of hands-on experience and intuition to improve the local sheep."

Mirlan Satybekov, Chairman of the Kyrgyz Public Association of Arashan Sheep Breeders and co-developer of the Arashan breed.

How did it all begin?

The history of the Arashan sheep breed dates back to the 1970s, when Hissar sheep were brought from Tajikistan to the city of Kant (Kyrgyzstan). The Hissar is renowned for its exceptional body weight, making it a leading breed among meat-and-fat sheep.
The imported Hissar sheep were systematically crossbred with local sheep. Over time, this process produced a distinct and consistent type of sheep that eventually became known as Arashan.
In animal breeding, a phenotype refers to an organism's observable characteristics.
The process may sound straightforward, but the Arashan breed is the product of decades of dedicated work by passionate sheep farmers. Drawing on their intuition and years of practical experience, they worked to improve local sheep. More than 30 years passed before it became clear that the resulting type had developed into a distinct breed, with its own defining



characteristics and advantages. In 2018, at a livestock exhibition in Shymkent (Kazakhstan), it became clear that the sheep developed through this breeding work did not belong to the Hissar breed. This prompted breeders to seek recognition for them as a new breed. On April 15, 2021, the new Kyrgyz sheep breed was officially registered. Today, it is widely known as Arashan.

What sets the Arashan breed apart?

Arashan is a meat-and-fat sheep breed and, by live weight, one of the largest sheep breed in the world. It is also among the tallest breeds at the withers.
Arashan sheep are hardy and well adapted to a wide range of environments, from high-mountain pastures to valley lowlands. They grow rapidly, gaining up to 550 grams per day in their first month, and are distinguished by their massive build and large fat tails. Their striking appearance also makes them stand out, attracting considerable interest from sheep enthusiasts and breeders alike.

What are the main challenges facing the development of the Arashan breed today?

In my view, not all breeders fully understand the principles of selective breeding. As a result, the breed's development has sometimes been haphazard, shaped more by commercial interests and prevailing trends than by sound scientific breeding practices.
This was one of the reasons a group of active sheep breeders in Kyrgyzstan established the Kyrgyz Public Association of Sheep Breeders in 2019. The Association was created to bring greater organization and direction to breeding efforts,



bridge the gap between practical experience and scientific knowledge, and encourage dialogue among sheep breeders, government agencies, and the business community.

The Association now brings together more than 2,700 farmers and has an established organizational structure, with coordinators overseeing activities at the district level. Regional and international exhibitions are held every year to document and showcase the best breeding results.

Much has already been accomplished, but a shortage of scientific expertise remains a significant challenge. Building that expertise must be a priority in the years ahead.

One important part of this effort is bonitation — the systematic evaluation of breeding animals. Although the practice continues to face criticism and resistance, it is a fundamental tool of scientific breeding and an internationally recognized practice. It is also essential to preserving and improving the breed.

Achievements

Today, we can confidently say that the Arashan breed is making significant progress. It has attracted interest beyond Kyrgyzstan, with strong demand from sheep breeders in Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, and Russia, as well as from more distant countries.

Work is underway to simplify the export of Arashan sheep, while discussions with government agencies and the business community continue to move forward. This year, our Association joined the Association for the Development of the Agro-Industrial Complex of the Kyrgyz Republic (APK KR). Through this partnership, we aim to establish Arashan as a distinctive breed brand in major international markets. Even so, I am convinced that the Arashan breed has yet to receive the recognition it truly deserves!

Arashan sheep: breeding or business?

The farm owned by Zamirbek Jainabekov and Zhanai Zhusupbekov was established five years ago and has already become one of the leading Arashan breeding operations. The farm has a flock of just 30 sheep, with the owners focusing not on numbers but on breed quality and genetic merit. Since 2024, their sheep have competed in exhibitions across Kyrgyzstan, earning top honors. Among the farm's best-known animals are Tsara, a ewe weighing 175.5 kg (387 lb), and Datka, a yearling ewe that set a record weight of 145 kg (320 lb). The farm also owns Darli Arabian, a ram with an impressive pedigree.

Zamir, could you tell us a little about yourself and how you got started in sheep breeding?

Before I started working with Arashan sheep, I spent many years breeding purebred horses, so I already understood the importance of pedigree and genetic merit. Five years ago, Zhanai and I decided to join forces and focus on breeding Arashan sheep. From the beginning, we concentrated on high-quality breeding animals, and in just five years, we have established our farm among the leading farms in the field. Our flock consists of 30 sheep. That may not sound like much, but behind that number are substantial investments, careful selection, and a great deal of hard work.

Since 2024, our sheep have won prizes at every exhibition they have entered. Many people know Tsara, our ewe weighing around 175 kg, and Datka, a yearling ewe with a record weight of 145 kg. We also have Darli Arabian, a ram with an outstanding pedigree.



Kochkor "Ak-bash"

Of course, we have experienced losses along the way. There are always risks in livestock farming, and you have to be prepared for them. On one occasion, we bought a lamb for $40,000, but it died some time later. We had expected it to be an investment in the future of our farm, but we lost the animal and all the plans we had built around it. In Arashan breeding, success depends not only on the quality of the flock and making the right purchasing decisions, but also on the farm's financial resilience. You need to be able to absorb losses and keep



working, investing, and developing your operation.

Wouldn't it be better to buy 100 sheep than to spend a large sum on a single expensive ram? What guides your decisions when you purchase a high-value animal for your farm?

Our approach to breeding is simple: we would rather buy one ram for $100,000 than 100 sheep.
In breeding, quality — not quantity — is what matters most.

When we purchase a ram, we expect it to produce offspring of sufficient quality and value to justify the investment. But how can we predict the quality of its offspring before buying it?

First, we look at the animal's pedigree, followed by its physical characteristics and conformation. A third crucial factor is the quality of the ewe flock and its size: there must be enough ewes for the ram to justify its price through the offspring produced in a single lambing season. As a rule, after the first lambing season, a breeder evaluates the results and decides whether the animal is worth continuing to use in the breeding program. For example, I currently have a high-quality, purebred yearling ram named Darli Arabian, sired by Frankel. He has an excellent pedigree and outstanding conformation. This year, his first lambs were born. One was sold to Uzbekistan, and that sale alone covered the cost of the ram. We also produced some excellent ewe lambs, which sold for $40,000–$50,000 each.
The quality of a ram's offspring is, in fact, one of the key factors determining both its breeding value and its market price.

"In livestock farming, there are always risks, and losses are inevitable. You have to be prepared for that."

If you start with animals that have weak genetic potential, the process of improving the flock and producing high-quality offspring becomes not just slower but potentially impossible.

Arashan sheep have become a popular business opportunity. In your view, is Arashan breeding ultimately about business or selective breeding?

It is true that interest in Arashan sheep has grown considerably. People from all kinds of backgrounds are getting involved, from experienced entrepreneurs to those who previously had no connection with either business or livestock farming.

I believe one reason for this growing interest is that people increasingly see livestock farming not merely as a traditional occupation but also as an investment opportunity and a way to build their own businesses. Sheep farming is attracting people

“In breeding, quality — not the number of animals — is the priority and the true measure of value.”

with substantial financial resources, and that, in turn, is giving breeding efforts an additional boost.
Over the past five years, the Arashan phenotype has changed significantly. Breeders’ ideas about desirable animal characteristics are evolving, expectations are rising, and new benchmarks are emerging for selective breeding.
I believe business and breeding are inseparable. Business provides the financial resources needed to develop a farm, acquire high-quality animals, and continue improving the breed. Selective breeding, in turn, creates long-term value for the operation.
In other words, money makes progress possible, but breeding determines the direction. I would not set these two goals against each other. Today, Arashan breeding is both a business and a breeding endeavor. The important thing is to ensure that commercial interests are always accompanied by a genuine commitment to improving the breed.



“Money makes progress possible, but breeding determines the direction.”

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Sheep are the best asset

"The time is approaching when the best possession of a Muslim will be sheep, which he will follow through mountain passes and grazing grounds in the rain, fleeing with his religion from temptation." — Hadith from Sahih al-Bukhari.

Abdulakhay Mikhmanov is a well-known sheep farmer and breeder with more than 12 years of experience in selective breeding. His farm has a flock of 50 high-quality purebred sheep. In 2019, a ram from his farm named Gulliver set a Central Asian weight record of 188 kg (414.5 lb).

How do you view sheep farming today?

When I first started raising sheep, breeding was driven purely by enthusiasm. It was not a job so much as a passion, something people did because they loved it. Selective breeding was not a highly profitable business back then. But by the will of the Almighty, Allah blessed our sheep breed with beauty and unique characteristics, increasing its value. As a result, people entering this field today see selective breeding as an opportunity to combine good earnings with an engaging pursuit. Recently, we held an Arashan breed festival to showcase the breed's strengths, introduce the public to the achievements of our breeding work, and inspire people to fall in love with Arashan sheep. Today, many affluent people, having discovered the beauty of Arashan sheep, want to take part in breeding and help increase the population of these remarkable animals. Arashan is a source of national pride, and it is only natural for people to want to contribute to such a worthy cause.



"Arashan is a source of national pride, and it is only natural for people to want to be a part of such a worthy cause."

In the past, being a shepherd was considered a low-status, disrespected occupation. Through the mercy of the Almighty and prayers of our grandfathers, who practiced sheep farming generation after generation, Allah has elevated this line of work to the status of an elite, prestigious, and fashionable business. Thanks to the results of our breeding work, we have become well known throughout Central Asia and gained recognition and a reputation in neighboring countries. I believe our next task is to make every effort to reach the global stage and earn international recognition.

What is your assessment of the progress being made in selective breeding? Is the direction right? Are you satisfied with the results?

Over the past five years, our breeding work has led not only to an increase in the sheep's weight but also to changes in their phenotype and conformation. At our recent festival, guests from Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan noted that our animals had become more attractive, with changes in the shape of their heads and fat tails. At the same time, their weight and height measurements have remained consistently strong and have continued to increase.



Кочкор «Вирус»

“I would advise newcomers to approach breeding with love and genuine interest.”

Of course, our breed is still young, and we have new goals for its further development. Nevertheless, the results we have achieved so far are already worthy of recognition.

Is it too late to start breeding Arashan sheep?

When someone loves what they do, it is never too late to start. Every farmer sets goals and works toward them with dedication. I would advise newcomers to approach breeding with love and genuine interest. There is no endpoint to developing a breed. Sheep breeding can be compared to horse breeding, where developing a breed can take centuries. If we stop the breeding process now, content with what we have achieved, we risk losing the breed. That is why anyone can start breeding Arashan sheep at any stage of its development. May Allah bless our breed with continued success and further achievements. Ameen.



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The Arashan Phenomenon

Shavkhet Shavkhetov Milyasovich is a sheep farmer and experienced breeder who has been actively involved in the selective breeding of Arashan sheep since 2016. He works with some of the country's leading sheep-breeding operations and maintains close professional ties with breeders throughout Kyrgyzstan, as well as in Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan.

How would you describe the current popularity of Arashan sheep and the buzz surrounding the breed?

For our people — the traditionally nomadic peoples of Central Asia — sheep farming has always been an integral part of life. Lamb has long held an important place in our diet, and no major celebration or gathering would be complete without it. Today, however, sheep farming is more than a way to preserve our ancestors' traditions. It is also a promising field with significant potential for growth. The prices commanded by some Arashan sheep have surprised not only people in Kyrgyzstan but also sheep enthusiasts abroad. Some consider these prices excessive, while others see them as the result of purposeful selective breeding and the growing value of high-quality breeding stock. We are seeing increased interest in livestock shows, more people entering the field of breeding, and substantial investments in animals with outstanding physical characteristics. These developments have sparked lively public debate, ranging from enthusiastic praise to controversy and, at times, outright criticism. What makes this particularly interesting is that the discussion goes beyond prices. It raises broader questions about the value of breeding animals, the importance of improving livestock genetics, and the future of sheep farming



in our region. That is why I would describe what is happening around Arashan sheep as a phenomenon in its own right.

"What we are witnessing today around Arashan sheep is what I would call the Arashan phenomenon."

When did Arashan sheep prices begin to rise?

Prices for Arashan sheep began to climb significantly in 2020–2021. In the years following the breed's registration, interest grew considerably, and the prices of the most valuable animals began to rise rapidly. Yet the breeding work is far from complete. Arashan is still a relatively young breed, and I believe it has considerable potential for further development. Breeders must continue refining its defining characteristics, improving the overall quality of their flocks, and ensuring that desirable traits are consistently passed on to future generations. I believe many achievements still lie ahead for our breed. Perhaps one day we will see Arashan sheep weighing 250 kilograms. For me, that is one of the possibilities that selective breeding may eventually pursue.

What prospects do you see for the Arashan breed?

I believe one of the key priorities is to expand exports and establish the breed in international markets. We are already seeing strong interest in Arashan sheep from buyers in Uzbekistan. Animals have also been purchased for Russia, while visitors from Moldova, the Czech Republic, Georgia, Turkey, and African countries have traveled to our region to see the breed firsthand. This interest shows that Arashan sheep are attracting attention well beyond Kyrgyzstan. But further development requires more than simply selling animals. We must strengthen the breed's reputation, continue improving its characteristics, and maintain high standards of breeding.
As long as demand exists, supply will continue to grow. Naturally, this affects both the market and animal prices. In my view, however, the long-term future of Arashan sheep will be determined not by prices alone, but above all by the results of our breeding work.

Your farm's Arashan sheep are in high demand among buyers from Uzbekistan. What attracts them most?

Above all, they are drawn to the animals' size, weight, and impressive appearance. The recent Arashan Breed Festival made a particularly strong impression on visitors. After the event, many became even more interested in raising Arashan sheep themselves. Our buyers from Uzbekistan pur-



Kochkor "ATM"

“The growing interest in Arashan sheep presents both an opportunity and a great responsibility for breeders.”

chase animals from us every year, gradually improving their flocks and strengthening their genetic potential. They have already achieved noticeable results, yet they continue to seek high-quality breeding rams and improve their herds. This is a natural part of serious breeding work: to keep moving forward, you must continually improve the quality of your livestock.

The Arashan phenomenon: a passing trend or the beginning of a new chapter in sheep farming?

In my view, the current interest in Arashan sheep presents both an opportunity and a great responsibility for breeders. High prices attract new participants to the market and give farms greater financial means to acquire valuable breeding animals and expand their selective breeding programs. International interest, in turn, creates opportunities to increase exports and raise the breed’s profile around the world. I believe in the future of Arashan sheep. What matters to me is that the breed should be judged not only by record-breaking weights and high prices, but also by the results of its breeding programs. Those results will show whether today’s interest can be sustained over the long term and what place Arashan



will ultimately hold in Kyrgyzstan’s livestock industry and in the international breeding community.

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A Model Sheep Farm

We visited a sheep farm established in 1997, and we believe it is no exaggeration to call it a model farm. Its strengths include its scale, decades of experience, consistent selective breeding, and commitment to developing the Arashan breed through a science-based approach.

A Passion for the Breed and Faith in Its Potential

The Arashan breed stands out for its distinctive characteristics: large size, powerful build, striking conformation, and strong meat-producing qualities.

Over time, working with these animals can become more than a profession. It becomes a pursuit that inspires a deep personal commitment. It was this passion for the breed and confidence in its potential that helped sustain the farm's breeding program even when Arashan sheep had not yet attracted the level of demand they enjoy today.

Over the past several decades, attitudes toward the breed have changed considerably. According to the farm owner, prices for Arashan sheep have risen over the years, reflecting sustained interest in the breed. He compares them to gold, expressing his confidence in their long-term value.

Selective Breeding as a Long-Term Commitment

One notable achievement of the farm's breeding program is the animals' impressive growth and stature. Some sheep stand at least three feet three inches tall at the withers. Such characteristics do not emerge

A model farm: scale, experience, systematic breeding, and a science-based approach.





by chance. They are the result of years of careful selection, pairing animals with desirable traits, and systematically improving the breeding ewe flock.

conformation, stature, and other defining breed characteristics. In the owner's view, selective breeding is already delivering tangible results, but the Arashan breed still has considerable room for improvement.
The objective is not simply to increase one characteristic at any cost. It is to improve the animals as a whole, strengthen desirable traits, and ensure that those traits are consistently passed on to future generations.

From Traditional Selection to a Science-Based Approach

The next stage in the farm's development involves closer collaboration between practical breeding and scientific research. The owner believes that further improvements to the breed should be supported by partnerships with the scientific community, the adoption of new technologies, and ongoing research.
Plans include supporting the preparation of scientific papers and dissertations focused on the Arashan breed and its breeding potential.

"Selective breeding is not about making a one-time investment in an exceptional animal or chasing records. It is a long-term commitment to improving a breed, one generation at a time."

According to the farm owner, substantially improving the quality of the breeding ewe flock can take seven to eight years.
The farm uses ewes with desirable breed characteristics, including descendants of well-known breeding rams. For example, the dams of some of the farm's ewes are daughters of ram called Gulliver, a notable ram from the farm of Don, an experienced breeder.
This approach illustrates why selective breeding must be viewed as a continuous process. It requires establishing a strong foundation of breeding females, carefully tracking each animal's lineage, and evaluating the results from successive generations.

The Arashan Breed Has Yet to Reach Its Full Potential

The farm does not regard its current achievements as the final goal. Instead, it sees them as a foundation for further progress.
Priorities include improving meat-producing qualities,

Such work could deepen our understanding of how breed characteristics are inherited, make it possible to evaluate breeding outcomes more precisely, and provide a stronger scientific foundation for the breed's continued development.
Bringing together the farm's accumulated practical experience and scientific research could make an important contribution to the advancement of the Arashan breed as a whole.

A Model of Systematic Breeding

What makes a sheep farm a model for others is not a single record-breaking animal or the size of its flock alone. It is the way the farm is managed, the consistency of its selection practices, the effective use of accumulated knowledge, and the clarity of its long-term goals.
The history of this farm demonstrates that developing a breed takes time, patience, and a willingness to continually refine breeding methods.

“Arashan sheep are like gold—they will always hold their value.” — The farm owner on the enduring value of the Arashan breed.

Nearly three decades of hands-on experience have laid the groundwork for the next step: bringing traditional breeding practices into closer alignment with scientific research.
That is the most important lesson this farm offers. Selective breeding is not about purchasing one exceptional animal or chasing an individual record. It is a sustained, carefully planned effort spanning generations, with the long-term goal of improving the breed.





“Emerald” Yearling Ewe

Video
“Model Farm”

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The Best Is Yet to Come

Ulan Uspekov Maratbekovich owns a sheep farm and has been raising purebred sheep for more than 12 years. His interest in working with animals and his first lessons in selective breeding began in childhood, when he learned from his father. Today, Ulan shares his perspective on modern sheep farming and the future of the Arashan breed.

What challenges have you faced in sheep farming?

One of the biggest challenges in selective breeding is the financial investment required. A purebred breeding ram or ewe can cost tens of thousands of dollars, making such purchases a serious financial burden for many breeders — and simply out of reach for some. I try to acquire high-quality breeding stock regularly because it is essential to the progress of my breeding program. As the quality of my flock improves, my standards for newly acquired rams and ewes become higher, and so do their prices.



"The most important ingredient for success in sheep farming is a genuine passion for working with sheep."

What do you focus on in your breeding program?

We carefully select our ewes and closely monitor the quality of their lambs. If I notice that a particular ewe consistently produces weak offspring or passes on undesirable traits when bred to a certain ram, I try to remove her from my breeding program. That does not necessarily mean the ewe has no breeding value. She may well improve the quality of another farm's flock. In other words, she may still be in demand, just better suited to a different breeding program.

My advice to beginning sheep



Kochkorik “Exhibit”

"I travel extensively and visit farms across the country, and I never cease to be amazed by what I see."

breeders is straightforward: do everything you can to build a strong foundation of high-quality breeding ewes. Of course, you can work with animals of varying quality, but the better your breeding females and rams, the faster you can make progress.
The results we achieved over more than a decade of work can be attained much sooner today, provided you have the financial resources to invest in high-quality breeding stock.

The ewe lambs on your farm could easily be mistaken for breeding rams. How do you feel about the progress made in breeding Arashan sheep?

The fact that my ewe lambs can be mistaken for rams is a sign that our breeding program is delivering good results.
I travel extensively and visit many different farms, and just like you, I am constantly amazed by what I see. Selective breeding in our country has reached such a pace and scale that I can find remarkable animals with impressive characteristics at virtually every farm I visit. And I am convinced that this progress will continue. The best results are still ahead of us.

What advice would you give to newcomers to Arashan sheep breeding?



Kochkor "Kind"

I encourage everyone who has an interest in sheep farming to pursue it. The most important ingredient for success is a genuine passion for working with sheep. If you have the desire and the interest, do not be afraid of setbacks. Work hard, do everything within your power, and put your trust in the Almighty. With the right intentions and sincere effort, sheep farming can become a source of barakah — blessing and abundance.

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Five Years Later

Arashan: Five Years of Selective Breeding and a Look Ahead

Five years is a relatively short time in the development of a breed, but it is long enough to assess the initial results of selective breeding, observe changes in a flock, and identify priorities for future development. Over this period, the Arashan breed has made significant progress. What began with official registration and a group of enthusiasts united by a common vision has grown into a breed attracting increasing interest from sheep farmers and livestock specialists. But what has actually changed over these five years? Have the breed's defining characteristics improved? Have the results lived up to the breeders' original expectations, and what challenges remain?
We discussed the results of five years of selective breeding, the progress achieved, and the breed's future prospects with Rishat Gabbazov, one of the co-developers of the Arashan breed.

Rishat Gabbazov is a well-known breeder with many years of experience, one of the co-developers of the Arashan sheep breed in Kyrgyzstan, an advocate for the breed, and the owner of a breeding farm.

Let's go back to the beginning. What goals did you have when you started breeding Arashan sheep, and how closely do today's results match your original vision?

Time flies! It feels like only yesterday that we registered the breed, driven by enthusiasm and a sense of patriotism, and came together to establish the Arashan Sheep Breeders' Association. Today, some of the difficulties we faced along the way are already beginning to fade from memory.
Many people doubted that the breed would succeed, although others supported us from the start.
At the time of registration, we had to assemble a population of at least 5,000 sheep. The solidarity of our regions made that possible: local communities in Talas and Issyk-Kul joined forces and contributed animals from their flocks.
Even then, I had a clear vision for developing my own farm.
I traveled extensively, visited other farms, learned from my colleagues' experience, and gradually established specific breeding goals.
My priority was to improve my own flock while preserving the meat-and-fat characteristics of our sheep.
I have always viewed Arashan as a breed with the potential to improve the productive qualities of meat-and-fat sheep in Central Asia and across the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS).
At the time, breeders were engaged in heated debates about Arashan's potential. Many specialists were skeptical of our plans. But there were also people who believed in the breed's future, including our colleagues in Ingushetia and Dagestan.
Looking back today, I believe we are moving in the right direction. But five years is only the beginning of a much longer journey.
Which results from these five years of selective breeding stand out most to you? Can we already see improvements in the breed's characteristics translating into practical benefits for sheep farmers?
One particularly telling example involves a farmer whose flock numbered around 1,300 sheep. He used to purchase sheep from Tajikistan and Kazakhstan, but over time, he began buying animals from us as well.

"I am convinced that we are only at the beginning of our breeding journey."

Later, he shared the results he had achieved by improving his flock. According to him, the minimum weight gain recorded among lambs sired by our Arashan rams was three kilograms.
For me, this was further evidence that the breed has the potential to improve the productive qualities of local sheep populations.
However, I am interested in more than achieving exceptional results in individual animals. I want desirable traits to be reliably passed on to future generations. That is one of the most important goals of our



“The results of five years of selective breeding have exceeded my expectations.”

ongoing breeding work.

Looking back on the five years since Arashan was registered, how would you assess the progress? What have you managed to change during that time?

I have to admit that the results of five years of selective breeding have exceeded my expectations. Here is a striking example. A few years ago, we would travel from farm to farm hoping to see a sheep standing 90 to 91 centimeters at the withers. Today, we travel to see rams standing a full meter tall.
Over the past five years, we have not only preserved the breed’s key characteristics but also improved them. Our main priorities have been live weight, height at the withers, and conformation.
The international Arashan Breed Festival was recently held. Can it be seen as a milestone marking the results of five years of work?
The festival’s primary purpose was to introduce the public to the results of our breeding efforts and give people an opportunity to see the distinctive qualities and advantages of our sheep firsthand.
It is impossible not to fall in love with Arashan sheep!
I am convinced that even people who are skeptical about the breed may change their minds after seeing our rams in person.
During and after the festival, we received a great deal of feedback from people who were impressed by the breed’s qualities.
I believe the festival helped bring greater attention to what we have achieved through our breeding work.

How would you assess the way selective breeding is organized today? What needs to change for the next five years to bring even greater results?

Today, Arashan breeding remains largely a grassroots effort. It is not regulated by the government, lacks a centralized management system, and has yet to be built on a unified scientific foundation.
Breeders work independently and often in isolation. As a result, achieving shared goals can take longer than necessary. I believe we need to act as a unified professional community and approach the development of the breed with greater



Kochkor “Turan”

"Arashan is a young breed. Its defining characteristics still need to be firmly established and refined. The breed's potential is far from exhausted."

coordination, responsibility, and expertise.
The next stage should involve a more systematic approach: clearly defined breeding objectives, careful evaluation of crossbreeding results, preservation of valuable traits, and greater exchange of knowledge and experience among farms.

What opportunities do the results achieved so far create for expanding the breed's reach?

I believe exporting meat and lamb could become a promising direction if we can substantially increase the size of the Arashan population. The rapid growth of Arashan lambs is one of the breed's key advantages and could make them attractive to markets in the Middle East.
But our strategic ambitions go beyond meat exports. We should aim to become a source of high-quality breeding stock for improving meat-and-fat sheep breeds in CIS countries, Turkey, Arab countries, and other nations interested in Arashan sheep.
The use of artificial insemination also creates additional opportunities to accelerate selective breeding and spread valuable genetic traits more widely.
To achieve these goals, we must not only increase the number of animals but also continue improving their quality.

Over the past five years, a community of sheep breeders interested in Arashan has taken shape. What advice would you give to those just starting out in selective breeding?

My advice to aspiring breeders is to set clear goals, study the hereditary characteristics of their animals, and carefully evaluate the results of each pairing. If you use inbreeding, you need to understand which traits you are trying to establish and account for the risks associated with mating closely related animals. That is why it is important to study specialized literature on animal breeding and genetics and apply that knowledge in practice.
And, of course, a breeder needs patience and the willingness to face challenges. Improving a breed is not a one-time achievement. It is a sustained



Ewe "Beauty"

“My advice to aspiring breeders is to set clear goals, study the hereditary traits of their animals, and carefully evaluate the results of each pairing.”



effort that continues across many generations.

Where do you see Arashan five years from now? Can we already speak of a finished product?

I am convinced that we are only at the beginning of our breeding journey.
Arashan is a young breed, and its defining characteristics still need to be firmly established and refined. I do not yet see our work as complete because every year we observe improvements in the animals and progress in the traits we consider priorities. The breed’s potential is far from exhausted. But future success will depend on how effectively we organize our breeding programs, whether we can unite the efforts of sheep breeders, and how consistently we pursue our goals. Five years ago, we began with an idea and a belief in Arashan’s future. Today, we have initial results, valuable experience, and a clearer understanding of the direction we need to take. The next stage lies ahead, and I am convinced that Arashan has a great future.

“5 Years Later” video

Rishat Gabbazov

Instagram:
@arashanigr

Arashan: A Dual Focus on Breeding and Meat Production

Ulan, owner of the Altyn Koylor farm, shares his experience and vision for the future of sheep farming.

Tell us about the leading breeding ram on your farm.

Our leading breeding ram is Achilles, a son of Frankel.
He is currently one year and five months old. We have already had lambs from him, and they are looking good.
This year, Achilles was part of our artificial insemination program. We have a large breeding ewe flock of 700 head, and he could not have covered all the ewes on his own. So we brought in specialists from Kazakhstan and spent two months, starting in August, artificially inseminating our ewes.
We prepared living quarters for the specialists, along with a laboratory equipped with the necessary equipment. Insemination was performed using the speculum method. We allowed the ewes to cycle naturally rather than inducing estrus.
In the morning and evening, we turned out teaser rams to identify receptive ewes, selecting 20 to 25 animals for insemination each day. Pregnancy has now been confirmed by ultrasound. The ewes that were bred by rams in April and May have already begun lambing. Approximately half were bred naturally, while the other half were artificially inseminated.

What criteria did you use to select this particular breeding ram?

When we bought Achilles, he was six months old. He had already sired lambs at his previous farm, so we were able to see his offspring later and assess their quality.
He stands 104 centimeters at the withers and passes on his length of body to his lambs. He has a beautiful, lustrous coat with subtle color variations, a broad chest, strong cannon bones, correctly set legs, considerable body length, a straight, firm back, and a well-positioned fat tail. And he is still growing.



"Selective breeding and meat production can go hand in hand."

You have been involved in various businesses, but now you have turned seriously to sheep farming. As a businessman, what strategy have you chosen?

My priority is to build a high-quality breeding ewe flock and use an outstanding breeding ram. We need to move entirely toward elite breeding stock because demand for quality breeding animals is especially high right now. I see this not only as a business but also as a hobby. Sheep breeding is not new to me; I have been involved in selective breeding for many years. Back in 2016, I brought in 100 large-framed Hissar sheep from Merke, Kazakhstan.
By gradually improving their characteristics, I developed the flock into what it is today.

Do you consider Arashan a promising breed for meat production?

I know farmers in Kazakhstan who manage a flock of 4,000 sheep. They have observed a substantial increase in meat productivity over the past five years. Today, they send eight-month-old ram lambs for slaughter, obtaining an average of 30 to 35 kilograms of meat per



Kochkor “Achilles”

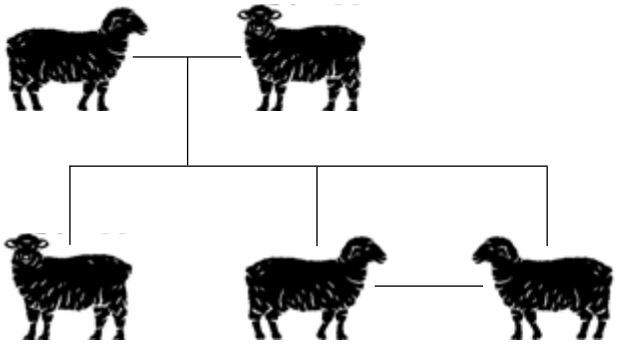


animal. Five years ago, lambs of the same age yielded around 15 to 18 kilograms. Based on their observations, that is a difference of approximately 15 kilograms per animal. In financial terms, my calculations suggest that an additional 15 kilograms of meat can increase the value of each lamb by around $120 to $130. Across an entire year's production, that could amount to hundreds of thousands of dollars.
Our breed helps improve the productive qualities of sheep, and that is the direction we are working toward. In time, perhaps we will also be managing 5,000 to 6,000 head and expanding our meat production. I would not rule out reaching meat yields of 40 to 50 kilograms from lambs aged eight to ten months. I believe selective breeding and meat production can go hand in hand.

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A Breeder's Glossary

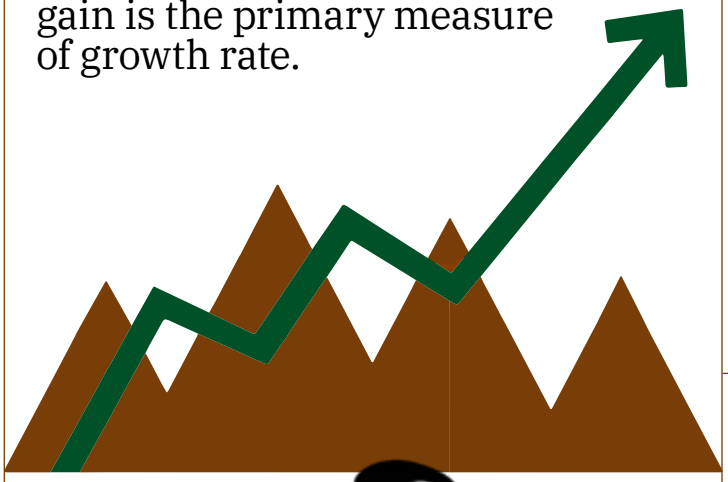


Inbreeding —
the mating of animals that are related to one another to some degree.

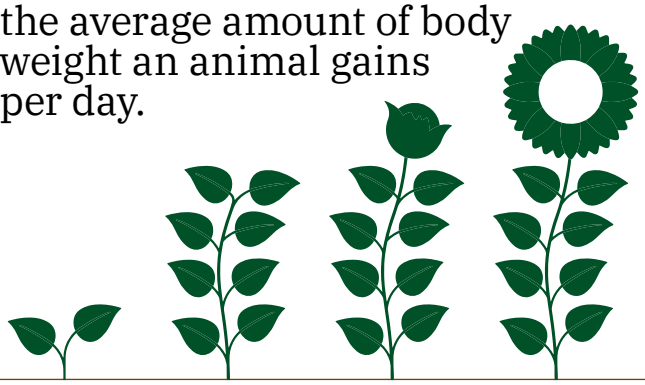


Heterosis —
also known as hybrid vigor, the tendency of first-generation hybrids to outperform their parents in one or more traits, such as viability, size, growth rate, and productivity.

Growth rate —
the average daily gain in a lamb's body weight over a given period. Average daily gain is the primary measure of growth rate.

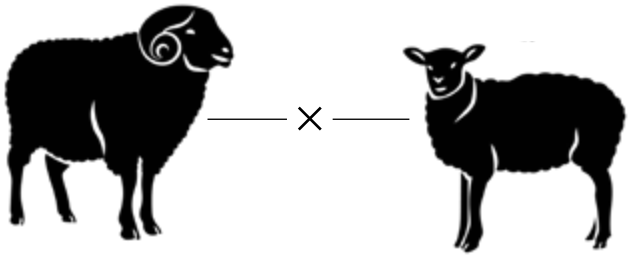


Average daily gain —
the average amount of body weight an animal gains per day.





Crossbreds —
offspring produced by mating animals of different breeds.



Crossbreeding —
a breeding method in which animals of different breeds are mated to produce offspring.

Breeding Built on Strong Genetics

Pansher Ismaev, regional coordinator of Arashan breeders, invited us to the Zam-Zam Arashan farm. He gave us a tour and spoke about the farm's breeding stock, its approach to sire selection, and the principles guiding its selective breeding program.

Every breeder sets their own goals and priorities. What is the main focus at Zam-Zam Arashan?

The farm works with three breeding rams representing valuable genetic lines. The ram Model produces lambs with desirable characteristics, while the ram Don is known for the quality of his ewe lambs, and the ram Iskander, a son of Exclusive, belongs to the Eighty line.
The breeding ewe flock also draws on several well-known lines, including rams Ship, Old Man, and Rhinoceros. In this way, the farm combines several sire and dam lines, paying close attention to the quality of both sides of each pairing.
This approach supports a consistent, long-term breeding program, helping establish desirable traits and achieve improvements in successive generations.
Particular attention is given to Model, a ram from the well-known Ship line. His sire is ram Image, and his dam is a ewe named Valide. Model stands out for his large frame, strong bone structure, and impressive conformation. His height at the withers is 102 cm (40 in). Other notable features in-



Kochkor «Iskander»

“The farm works with several sire and dam lines, paying close attention to the quality of both sides of each pairing.”

clude the shape of his head, chest structure, leg set, and fat-tail conformation. A valuable breeding animal is defined not by one outstanding feature alone, but by the combination of traits considered when evaluating conformation and determining future breeding priorities.



Ewe “Cinderella”

Does the farm follow a special feeding program to produce large, well-developed Arashan sheep?

Our feeding program is not fundamentally different from those used for other sheep. It includes hay, clover, seasonal succulent feeds such as pumpkin and carrots, and compound feed. We also use premixes containing essential minerals and vitamins. We do not give any special growth-promoting supplements.
For lambs, the farm uses Sedimin, a preparation containing iron, iodine, and selenium. Weak lambs may also receive multivitamin preparations when needed.
We place particular importance on pasture grazing and daily exercise, which are especially important for pregnant ewes. During the final month of pregnancy, we make sure they have the opportunity to walk in an exercise pen for three to four hours a day. This routine helps maintain their physical activity. It is also important to manage feeding and exercise carefully during this period and avoid excessive weight gain, which can make lambing more difficult.

As the reagional coordinator, could you tell us about the current situation among breeders in your local community?

Today, the regional community of sheep breeders brings together around 160 Arashan breeders. Many of them are young people who are interested in raising this breed.
Despite urbanization, young people are showing an interest in farming. They are building barns, acquiring livestock, carrying out conformation assessments, and working to improve the breed.
Part of Arashan’s appeal is that selective breeding can produce noticeable results in a relatively

“Despite urbanization, young people are showing an interest in farming. They are building barns, acquiring livestock, evaluating breeding animals, and working to improve the breed.”



short time. This attracts newcomers, although raising breeding stock, like any farming venture, requires investment, knowledge, and a willingness to take risks.

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Kochkor “Sample”

Sheep Have a Way of Softening the Heart

Umar Kamirdinov, owner of the Aisberg-2 farm in Novopokrovka, manages a flock of 90 breeding sheep. He spoke with us about his work, his relationship with his animals, and his vision for the future of sheep farming.

What are your secrets to caring for sheep?

There are no special secrets. Clover, hay, compound feed — the usual routine. I don't overuse vitamins or special supplements, except in specific situations when an animal becomes ill or needs additional support.
I believe the best approach to animal care is natural prevention: feeding and watering on time, regular exercise, bathing, and disease prevention.
Personally, I don't have the opportunity to let my sheep graze on pasture, although I believe that is the ideal way to keep them.
From an aesthetic standpoint, sheep kept in stalls may look more impressive than those out grazing in the fields. But what matters most is that pasture-raised animals are healthier, more athletic, stronger, and more resilient.

"I've noticed that sheep teach people kindness and love."



"The Italian" Kochkorik

What challenges do you face in your work?

When you treat animals with love, the work doesn't seem so difficult. I remember a conversation with some friends when we were discussing which professions were the most demanding. At first, we listed different kinds of work, such as running a country or managing a factory. But eventually, we came to the conclusion that sheep farming is also one of the toughest jobs there is. Just think about it: farmers don't get weekends, holidays, or vacations. Animals cannot wait. They need to be fed on time, every day, without fail. Caring for them is a major responsibility and a daily commitment.

People say that sheep change the person who cares for them. Have you noticed that yourself?

An acquaintance once told me that people have known since ancient times that caring for sheep softens the heart and makes a person kinder. I've always loved animals, but now I pay even closer attention to them. Sheep have personalities of their own, just like people. For example, my ram, Aisberg-2, has a calm temperament, while another ram, named Italian, is lively and energetic. I've noticed that sheep teach people kindness and love. When I come to the farm after work and the bustle of city life, I enjoy being there. It gives me a chance to unwind and find peace of mind.



How do you assess the current state of sheep farming in Kyrgyzstan?

Farms that fell into disrepair during the Soviet era are gradually being restored, and forgotten skills and crafts are making a comeback. You could say that the livestock sector is experiencing a revival. A healthy spirit of competition has emerged among sheep breeders. Everyone wants to raise high-quality ewe lambs and produce an outstanding breeding ram. We're constantly asking one another, "What have your ewes lambed this season? And yours?" We visit each other's farms, examine breeding results, and compare achievements. All of this helps move the industry forward. Cooperation with other Central Asian countries is also growing, and a memorandum has been signed with Uzbekistan. Kyrgyzstan is becoming one of the centers for the development of pedigree sheep breeding and the expansion of the Arashan breed. This is a very positive development

"When you treat animals with love, the work doesn't seem so difficult."



Kochkor “Iceberg-2”

for us. Of course, there is criticism, too, but I take it in stride. Every movement has its supporters and its opponents. Interest in Arashan sheep is growing so quickly that today, almost every village has a farm breeding them. Experienced breeders predict that the record live weight could eventually reach 250 kilograms. Farms are also establishing their own laboratories, which should give sheep farming a new boost, particularly in selective breeding.

How do you see the future of sheep farming in Kyrgyzstan?

Kyrgyzstan has enormous potential for sheep farming: extensive pastureland, abundant water resources, and favorable climatic conditions. With government support, Arashan breeding could become a strategically important sector of the economy. Sound planning and the consistent development of livestock farming would allow us not only to meet domestic demand for meat but also to supply neighboring countries. I am confident that Kyrgyz meat will find a market thanks to its natural qualities, purity, and excellent taste.



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A Hobby for Real Men

Rysbek Mambetkulov and Suyutbek Atymyrzaev, owners of "Kyzyl-Zhar" Farm, share their experience breeding Arashan sheep, the results of their selective breeding efforts, and what it takes to succeed in sheep farming.

Tell us your story.

Before we started breeding Arashan sheep, we kept ordinary rams — around 100 head — but the business was not particularly profitable. Over the past few years, we gradually shifted to purebred animals.

Today, our main breeding ram is Kremlin, a son of the ram Frankel. When we bought him, I planned to mate him only with top-quality ewes to produce high-quality offspring. I even kept a special breeding log. Over time, however, experience showed that the lambs turned out to be roughly the same quality regardless of the ewes' classification. We sold his lambs for between $20,000 and $40,000 each. Their new owners were highly impressed with the animals they had purchased and kept them in their own flocks as principal breeding rams. According to our information, some of these animals are now so highly valued that their owners would not sell them even for $100,000–$150,000.

"Arashan breeding is not for the faint of heart."

I bought Kremlin when he was four and a half months old for $45,000. Since then, we have sold 13 lambs at just six weeks of age for a total of $235,000.

When people heard how much



Kochkor "Kremlin"



Kochkor “Aksy”



“If you lack sufficient knowledge and experience, be sure to hire a specialist who has them.”

our ram had cost, many were surprised and thought the price was excessive. But once they saw his breeding value and the results he produced, they began buying his lambs from us themselves.
In our view, the quality of Arashan sheep has improved so much that selective breeding is now taking place within the breed itself.
We have met sheep breeders who traded ten good animals for a single one with superior characteristics. This shows that, for many breeders, quality is becoming more important than quantity.
To succeed in sheep farming and make it profitable, you need a thorough understanding of the animals and a good instinct — one that develops over years of experience and close, continuous observation.

What advice would you give to people just starting out in Arashan breeding?

I see many business people becoming interested in Arashan sheep, including those who previously had little or no experience with livestock. Some have come to believe that buying expensive animals is enough to make a quick fortune. But sheep farming can involve serious mistakes and financial losses. The only way to minimize the risks is to take a knowledgeable, experience-based approach.
So my advice to anyone planning to start breeding Arashan sheep is this: if you do not yet have enough knowledge and experience, be sure to hire a specialist who does. This will significantly improve your chances of success.
Overall, Arashan breeding is not for the faint of heart. You need to be willing to take risks, remain level-headed when losses occur, recover quickly from setbacks, and have the confidence to make decisions.



Video
“It’s just the beginning”

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A Nomadic Legacy

Dastan Usenov and Kutmanaly Surapbaev are the owners of “Nakta Arashan” farm. Today, we spoke with Dastan, the son of one of the founders of the Arashan sheep breed.

How did you get started in sheep farming?

Sheep have been part of my life since childhood. My father was one of the founders of the Arashan breed and devoted many years to sheep farming. He always took me along when he visited other farms, and I learned a great deal from him.

“Sheep farming is, above all, something I truly enjoy.”



Kochkorik “Emperor”

I gained hands-on experience by helping out on our own farm. After my father passed away, I decided to carry on his work. I began developing the farm, and today we are already seeing tangible results.

Many young people choose other lines of business, yet more and more young people in Kyrgyzstan are becoming interested in farming. What opportunities do you see for yourself in this field?

I am convinced that farming has a bright future in Kyrgyzstan. First of all, sheep farming is something I genuinely enjoy. It is work that speaks to my heart. Second, the growing popularity of Arashan sheep, both at home and abroad, gives the business strong financial potential. And finally, this work was passed down to me by my father, and it has been close to my heart since childhood.
Sheep farming has always been part of the lives of nomadic peoples. It is deeply rooted in our heritage — a tradition passed down by our ancestors.

How do your peers and friends feel about what you do?

I have a friend whom I was always encouraging to take up sheep farming, specifically Arashan breeding. Whenever he came to visit, I would try to spark his interest by telling him about Arashan sheep, but he never

Cholpon Koichukenov, one of the founders of the breed



"Breeding takes patience, a keen eye, curiosity, knowledge, and hard work."

seemed particularly interested. One day, I gave him a pair of ewe lambs, and that was how he began breeding sheep. Today, he is one of the leading Arashan breeders. His sheep win prizes at livestock shows. Now many of my friends run farms alongside their primary jobs. Of course, farming is not for everyone. Sheep breeding and selective breeding require patience, a keen eye, curiosity, knowledge, and hard work. It is especially unsuited to those who expect to make money quickly. I remember how happy my father was when he saw the results of his breeding work. I remember his enthusiasm and how deeply he immersed himself in the process. I believe I inherited that same attitude toward the work. It is a love of animals and of the process itself that keeps you moving steadily toward your goals. In breeding, the goals are usually long-term; results rarely come quickly. For example, my brother and I have been working for four years now to build a high-quality, uniform breeding flock of ewes. We make occasional sales, but for the most part, we continue investing in the farm.

How does your family feel about your work in farming?

My family supports me in everything because this is the work my father began. My father, Cholpon Koichukenov, is well known among those who helped establish the Arashan breed. He was the one who gave the legendary breeding ram Ship his name. He also took part in the 2018 livestock show in Shymkent, an event that became an important milestone in the development of our breed. My father left me more than just a farm. He passed on his attitude toward farming and his respect for animals.

What is your outlook on the future of the Arashan breed?

The breed's current popularity is already compelling evidence of its potential. I see strong interest from breeders in other countries. Some contact me directly because they want to visit and see our sheep in person. Many are exploring the possibility of exporting Arashan sheep to the Middle East and Europe. For us, it is important not only to develop our own farms but also to show the world that the Kyrgyz Arashan breed deserves the attention of breeders everywhere.





“Dior” Yearling Ewe

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Signs You're an Arashan Breeder

1 

Your wife knows exactly how much a good breeding ram costs these days.

2

Your family knows all about conformation and breeding lines.

3

You step into the sheep barn for five minutes and come out several hours later.

4

You meet someone new, and within ten minutes, you're talking about Arashan sheep.

5 

You were planning to upgrade your car, but put it off yet again because you bought a ram instead.

6

Your phone gallery has more pictures of rams than pictures of your own family.

7

You look at your friends' children and instinctively wonder who they take after and which traits they've inherited from their parents.

Then you catch yourself and realize you do exactly the same thing when looking at rams.

8

You head out to run errands and come home with a new ram because "you just couldn't pass up an opportunity like that."

9

You can't drive past a flock without slowing down to get a closer look at the rams.

10

Your children know the names of the most expensive rams.





One Ram makes a Big Difference

Azat Oskonbaev and Rasul Mansurov are experienced breeders specializing in Arashan sheep. The focus of our interview is Fantastic, a breeding ram who is an outstanding representative of the breed and a testament to the farm's selective breeding work.

Tell us about Fantastic's pedigree.

Fantastic, our farm's principal breeding ram, is the son of the well-known ram Don, who descends from Gulliver through the Ship line. This established breeding line played an important role in the breed's registration. In 2019, Gulliver recorded a remarkable weight of 188 kg at a regional livestock show in Shymkent, making a strong impression on sheep breeders. Gulliver sired Narbudan, Narbudan sired Don, and Don is the sire of our current breeding ram, Fantastic. Fantastic's dam is a daughter of a ewe named Lampochka. She earned this name because of the unusual shape of her ears — a trait that she passed on to Fantastic as well.

What makes Fantastic stand out?

He began breeding ewes at just five months of age. After a trial mating, we saw his potential and became convinced of his breeding value. At five months, we put him to 12 test ewes classified as first-class, elite, and super-elite. He achieved good results in passing on coat color, breed-type purity, conformation, and head and ear shape.





Kochkor “Fantastic”

His ears measure 25 cm (9.8 in), and his height at the withers is 104 cm (41 in).
One of Fantastic's main advantages, in our observation, is the quality of his offspring from ewes of different breeding classes.
We even used him on lower-quality ewes, and the lambs turned out excellent.
We purchased Fantastic at four months of age for $33,500.
He is now a year and a half old.
We believe a breeding ram of this caliber can quickly pay for himself.

What, in your view, determines Fantastic's breeding value?

The breeding value of a ram is determined above all by his ability to pass desirable traits on to his offspring. In our experience, Fantastic performs well in this regard.
At just a year and a half old, he is already demonstrating his potential. As a result, breeders are showing interest in him, and demand remains high for his lambs, both ewe lambs and ram lambs. We expect the valuable traits of the Ship and Lampochka lines to be passed on to future generations, including through Fantastic's sons.



"The breeding value of a ram is determined above all by his ability to pass desirable traits on to his offspring."

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Arashan: A Breed with Unique Characteristics

Rakhat Abitovich Ibraev, Candidate of Agricultural Sciences, Director of the Kyrgyz Research Institute of Livestock and Pastures

From Local Sheep to the Arashan Breed

For generations, people in Kyrgyzstan have raised local fat-tailed sheep well adapted to the country's mountainous pastures. The Hissar breed has also played an important role in meat-and-fat sheep production, renowned for its large size and pronounced meat-and-fat characteristics.
In the early 1970s, work began at a machine testing station in the Chui Region to develop a new type of sheep. Local fat-tailed ewes were crossed with Hissar rams. The goal was to produce animals with greater live weight and well-developed meat-and-fat characteristics while retaining the traits needed to thrive in local conditions.
However, the desired results could not be achieved through the initial crossbreeding alone. The animals continued to be selectively bred over successive generations, with the aim of fixing the desired traits. Through this long-term breeding process, the Arashan sheep type gradually took shape.
An important milestone was the molecular genetic analysis of Arashan sheep conducted at the Federal Research Center for Animal Husbandry in Russia. The results showed that the group of Arashan sheep studied was genetically differentiated from the Hissar and Edilbay breeds. This provided evidence that Arashan has its own genetic characteristics and is not



Kochkor "Etalon"

simply a line within another breed.

What Makes Arashan Sheep Distinctive?

The defining feature of Arashan sheep is their pronounced meat-and-fat type. When evaluating these animals, breeders look for large body size, a strong constitution, a well-developed body, and balanced overall conformation. For a breeding farm, the goal is not simply to produce a heavy animal but to preserve a combination of desirable traits. Selection therefore takes into account live weight, body development, leg soundness, and overall health. The animals' pedigree, the productivity of their parents, and the performance of their offspring are equally important.



Key Characteristics

Breed type: Meat-and-fat (fat-tailed)

Live Weight and Height at the Withers:

180–215 kg
weigh adult breeding rams (2.5 years and older) with a record live weight of **236 kg**

98–111 cm
reaches height at the withers

120–140 kg
weigh breeding ewes with a record live weight of **175.5 kg**

90–99 cm
reaches height at the withers

55 kg
lambs can weigh up to at six months of age yielding up to 30 kg of meat, as reported

Distinctive Physical Characteristics:
Pronounced convex (Roman-nosed) profile
Long, pendulous ears measuring 20–25 cm
Polled (naturally hornless)
Large, well-developed fat tail
Coat colors: reddish, red, black, and brown

Adaptability:
Well adapted to mountain pastures, valleys, and stall-based housing.

Growth and reproduction:
High growth potential, with reported daily weight gains of 450–550 gram. Body weight at one month of age is reported to reach up to 25 kg.
Birth weights range from 7 to 12 kg.

Minimum Performance Standards for Arashan Rams

Breeding class	Age: 1 year			Age: 2 years			Age: 3 years and older		
	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm
Elite	**90**	**90**	**20**	**120**	**94**	**20**	**140**	**97**	**20**
Class I	**80**	**87**	**17**	**110**	**91**	**17**	**130**	**94**	**17**
Class II	**70**	**84**	**17**	**100**	**88**	**17**	**120**	**90**	**17**

Minimum Performance Standards for Arashan Ewes

Breeding class	Age: 1 year			Age: 2 years			Age: 3 years and older		
	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm	Live weight, kg	Height at withers, cm	Ear length, cm
Elite	**70**	**86**	**20**	**80**	**86**	**20**	**90**	**87**	**20**
Class I	**60**	**83**	**17**	**70**	**83**	**17**	**80**	**84**	**17**
Class II	**50**	**79**	**17**	**60**	**79**	**17**	**70**	**80**	**17**



Arashan Sheep: Prospects for the European Market

Vladimir Menčík, a farmer from the Czech Republic and owner of M&M bio farma Šonov in the town of Šonov, visited Kyrgyzstan and several farms breeding Arashan sheep. He shared his impressions and discussed the breed's potential in Europe.

Although European farmers predominantly raise meat breeds and lamb and mutton are consumed less frequently in general, demand for meat-and-fat sheep breeds has been growing steadily in recent years. In the farmer's view, one reason is the growing number of migrants from the Middle East and Africa.



Ewe "Arzu"

Tell us about your visit to Kyrgyzstan.

This is my first visit to Kyrgyzstan. Before this, I visited Kazakhstan, where I learned about the Edilbay breed and first heard about Arashan. I had been hearing about this breed for a long time, and I wanted to see these animals for myself.
Of course, I am very impressed by Arashan sheep, their size, and their growth rate. Thanks to these characteristics, they can be ready for slaughter as early as eight to nine months of age.
There is a market for lamb in Europe, and if we were raising Arashan sheep, we could obtain significantly more meat from each animal at eight to nine months of age.
If I had the opportunity, I would definitely pursue the export of Arashan sheep to the Czech Republic. Muslims who have moved here from predominantly Muslim countries often contact me.
If Arashan sheep were introduced to Europe, they could become popular, at least in the halal food market.
I visited farms in the Chui Region and Karakol, and I am very happy for my colleagues in Kyrgyzstan. It is wonderful to see their achievements in selective breeding and the conditions in which they work.

What is the current state of farming in the Czech Republic?

The reality is that farming in the Czech Republic and other European Union countries is challenging because of the large number of inspections and regulatory authorities. We have strict requirements for veterinary



oversight and meat production. For example, on my farm, I can have only two cows slaughtered.
The slaughter must take place at a specialized abattoir, and I pay €700 to have a cow slaughtered and the meat returned to me.
Sheep farming faces another problem as well. Wolf hunting is strictly prohibited in the Czech Republic, and killing a wolf can carry a prison sentence of up to three years. As a result, wolf numbers in our region have grown so much that they pose a real threat to sheep. I have to keep 20 dogs on my farm to protect the flock, and maintaining that many dogs is expensive.
In addition, farming does not appeal strongly to many young people in Europe. Many prefer working in an office.
All these challenges make choosing the right breed especially important.
Under these conditions, raising highly productive sheep can, in my view, be one way to improve a farm's economic performance. That is precisely why I consider the Arashan breed interesting and promising for European farmers.



Kochkor “Melburg-2”

Establishing a Reproductive Biotechnology Laboratory for Arashan Sheep: Initial Work on Laparoscopic Artificial Insemination and the MOET Program

Scientific and Practical Report

By Sardor Noruzbaev and Ilyas Khidzhunyi

Abstract

A specialized laboratory focused on reproductive biotechnologies for Arashan sheep has been technically launched in the Kyrgyz Republic. The laboratory is equipped to assess sperm quality and motility, cryopreserve and thaw semen and embryos, perform laparoscopic artificial insemination, and implement a multiple ovulation and embryo transfer (MOET) program.
The initial practical work included animal preparation and laparoscopic artificial insemination. The program includes the collection, evaluation, and transfer of embryos to recipient ewes. The introduction of these methods creates opportunities to improve breeding traits and preserve valuable genetic material from the breed.

Keywords: Arashan, sheep farming, laparoscopic artificial insemination, MOET, embryo transfer, cryopreservation, selective breeding.

Introduction

Modern sheep farming requires scientific approaches to reproduction and the preservation of valuable breed characteristics. For the Arashan breed, which is important to livestock production in Kyrgyzstan, the introduction of advanced reproductive and selection technologies is of practical interest.
The opening of the laboratory marks a step toward integrating biological material assessment, artificial insemination, and embryo transfer.

Materials and Methods

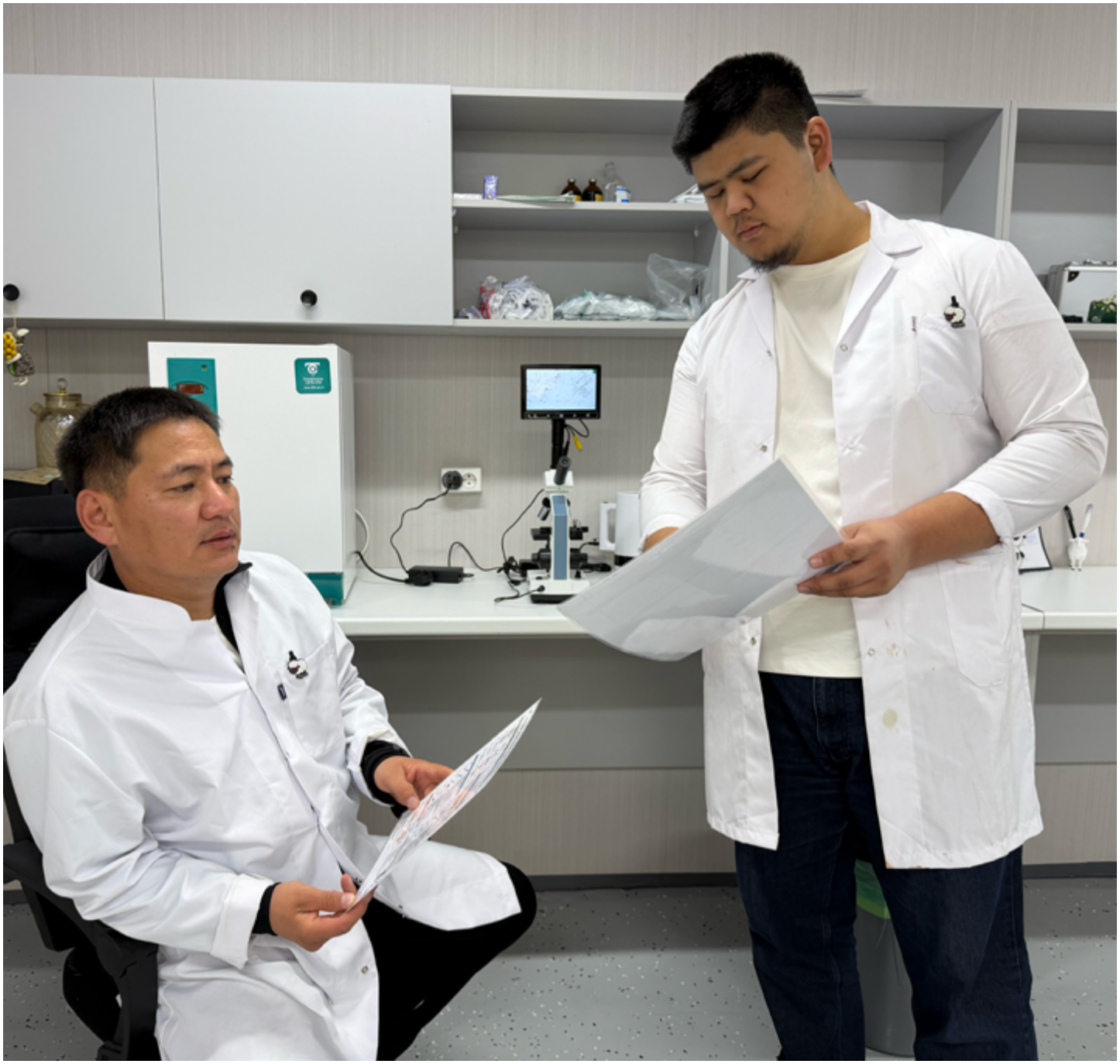
The laboratory is equipped for semen quality assessment, semen freezing and thawing, and embryo handling. Its program includes laparoscopic artificial insemination and multiple ovulation and embryo transfer (MOET).
Donor ewes undergo preparation and estrous cycle synchronization. Following hormonal stimulation, insemination is performed according to the selected protocol. The subsequent stages include embryo collection, microscopic assessment of embryo developmental stage and quality, and transfer of suitable embryos to synchronized recipient ewes. Specific medications, dosages, and quantitative parameters were not provided in the source data.

Initial Work and Scientific and Practical Significance

Laparoscopic artificial insemination provides a foundation for implementing modern reproductive technologies. MOET is intended to make more intensive use of the genetic potential of valuable breeding ewes, while the cryopreservation of semen and embryos allows biological material to be preserved for future use in selective breeding programs.

Results and Future Prospects

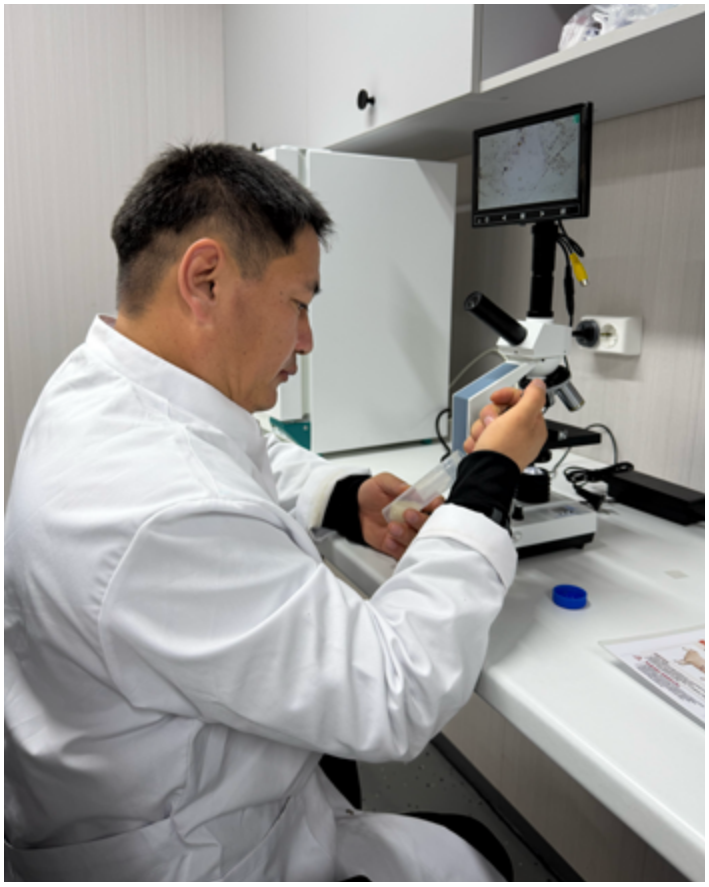
The establishment of the laboratory infrastructure



“The opening of the laboratory is an important step toward advancing modern selective breeding in Arashan sheep. The use of reproductive biotechnologies will make it possible to systematically evaluate semen, reproduce genetically valuable animals, and preserve the breed’s genetic potential. The next stage is to collect objective data to assess the effectiveness of these methods.”

“Our goal is to introduce laparoscopic artificial insemination and embryo transfer technologies in a systematic manner, improve breeding practices, and raise the overall quality of the flock. We aim to combine scientific methods with practical experience to preserve the valuable characteristics of the Arashan breed and support its continued development.”

and the completion of initial laparoscopic artificial insemination work have been confirmed.
Data on the number of animals involved, the number of embryos collected and transferred, pregnancy rates, and lambing outcomes have not yet been provided. Therefore, the program’s effectiveness cannot currently be assessed quantitatively.
Future work should systematically record semen quality, the number and quality of embryos, transfer outcomes, pregnancy rates, and offspring survival.



Conclusion

The establishment of a laboratory dedicated to reproductive technologies for Arashan sheep represents an important milestone in the development of reproductive biotechnology in Kyrgyzstan. Combining semen evaluation, cryopreservation, laparoscopic artificial insemination, and MOET could expand the possibilities for selective breeding and the preservation of valuable genetic resources. Further work should be accompanied by systematic data collection and scientific evaluation of the effectiveness of these methods.

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Karakol: A Brotherhood Tested by Time

Editor's perspective

"A believer to another believer is like a building, each part of which strengthens the others." —

Hadith, Sahih Muslim, 2585

When I began traveling around Kyrgyzstan to visit farms, my first long-distance trip took me to Karakol. I had heard a great deal about the close-knit community of Arashan breeders there, and I wanted to see for myself what lay behind their strong sense of brotherhood and mutual respect. What struck me was that behind the familiar structure of the jamaat (community) stood a truly strong team, with each member playing a distinct role. Over years of working together, these farmers had maintained their unity and mutual trust. They knew how to reach agreements, coordinate which animals to present at livestock shows and fairs, and do so without conflict, while respecting one another's interests.

Everyone here contributes something to the common cause. Ruslan Muraev and Khalmet Khalmurzaev are experienced breeders whose opinions help the group reach balanced and fair decisions. Kutman Kokulov and Bakyt Toroev pay particular attention to selective breeding and see opportunities for the breed's development. Aibek Saparbekov takes a business-minded approach, while Azamat Talipov has a strategic vision for their shared endeavors. Their different qualities and perspectives do not divide them; on the contrary, they complement one another.

According to Salamat Abylaev, coordinator of the Karakol jamaat, the breeders are united by common goals, shared interests, and a common vision for the future. Yet Arashan breeding is about more than work and calculations; it also brings powerful emotions. This is especially true in spring and autumn, during lambing season, when the arrival of new lambs brings joy and renewed enthusiasm. The Karakol jamaat was one of the first groups in which breeders began pooling their money to purchase breeding rams. Such an arrangement requires more than shared interests; it requires trust. Everyone understands that they are





Kochkor “09”

investing not only in their own farm but also in a shared future.

One story that particularly stayed with me was how the jamaat helped a young local farmer establish his first flock through a collective effort. Today, he is an established Arashan breeder and a full-fledged member of this close-knit team.
I returned to that trip in my thoughts many times, wondering what lay behind such warm relationships. I believe much of it comes down to a deep sense of accountability before God, a love of their work, and a willingness to stand by one another. This is evident in the decisions they make together, in their readiness to help those just starting out, and in the genuine hospitality with which the Karakol farmers welcome their guests.
Although long journeys can be exhausting, the road to Karakol always seems to fly by. I am invariably welcomed warmly, people make time to talk, and they generously share their experience. Perhaps that is why I have come to visit Karakol more often than any other region of Kyrgyzstan. What draws me back is not only my interest in Arashan sheep, but also the people who remind me, more than anywhere else, of the true value of brotherhood.



Kochkor “09”

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Selection and Mating: The Foundation of Breeding Work

Ramil Dunlaza, owner of “Crystal-Arashan” Farm, spoke with us about the principles of selecting a breeding ram and shared his own experience.

How do you choose a young ram that will live up to expectations and become a good breeding sire?

First and foremost, pedigree matters: the animal’s bloodline, its genetics, and the line it belongs to. Then you need to determine which characteristics your farm specifically requires and choose a line that meets those needs. Only then should you select the most promising ram lamb from that line. A great deal depends on personal experience, and every breeder has their own.

What guides a breeder when choosing one lamb from among many?

A trained eye, years of experience, and individual intuition. Every breeder develops their own perspective over the years. Among experienced breeders — the real old hands — I would especially

“You need to understand what kind of animals your farm requires, study pedigrees, and gain experience.”



Kochkor “Abu Dhabi”

“Over time, you begin to notice things you would have overlooked before.”

single out Hasan. He has an almost infallible instinct for recognizing a good ram.

And how did you choose your breeding ram, Abu Dhabi?

I first saw him when he was two months old. I looked at him again at four months, and I bought him when he was six months old. Among the lambs sired by Abu Dhabi, I immediately noticed Cosmos. He stood out from his brothers: he had a different bone structure, a large head, and different ears. Overall, he looked distinct, and it caught my eye right away. I kept watching him grow and, over time, became convinced that my initial impression had been right. In the end, I decided to keep Cosmos in my own flock, even though many people wanted to buy him.

What is Cosmos like today?

He is now a year and a half old. His height at the withers is 103 cm (40.6 in), and his ears are 24 cm (9.4 in) long. He has a large, massive head. He has already sired some trial offspring, and I am pleased with their quality. From what I have observed, Cosmos passes on his large size to his offspring. Lambs can weigh 10–11 kg (22–24 lb) at birth. However, their large size calls for special attention during lambing: in some cases, the ewes need assistance.

What advice would you give to those just starting out in pedigree sheep breeding?

First, you need to understand what kind of animals your farm requires, study pedigrees, and gain experience. But knowing a pedigree alone is not enough. You need to look at a lot of animals, compare them, and observe how they develop. Over time, you begin to notice things you would have overlooked before. That is how you develop a trained eye and your own instinct as a breeder.

Selection and Mating: The Foundation of Breeding Work

Selection is the process of choosing animals best suited for further breeding. Their ancestry, conformation, productivity, and other traits are taken into account. Since an animal’s genetic potential cannot always be accurately assessed from its external characteristics, evaluating its offspring plays an important role.

Assessing breeding rams by the quality of their offspring is particularly important. This helps determine how consistently an animal passes desirable traits on to the next generation.

Breeding programs also use performance appraisal (bonitation) — a comprehensive evaluation of animals that helps identify the best candidates and those whose qualities do not meet breeding requirements.

Mating selection is the purposeful choice of animals to be paired for breeding. Its goal is to produce offspring with desirable characteristics, preserve and strengthen useful traits, and, where possible, eliminate shortcomings.

In short, selection helps determine which animals should be retained in the breeding flock, while mating selection determines which pairs are most likely to produce the desired offspring. Together, these tools form the foundation of systematic flock improvement.

*Prepared by the editorial team based on the textbook Sheep Breeding, *by V. K. Toshchev and E. V. Tsaregorodtseva. — Yurait, 2024.*

Kochkor “Cosmos”



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International Exhibition of the “Arashan” Breed

June 6, 2026, city of Cholpon-Ata, Issyk-Kul Region














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I-ОРУН
ЖЕЛМАЯН


АЛАМУДУН
АРАШАН







The First International Arashan Sheep Breed Festival September 18–19, 2026, Bishkek












































Қош келдіңіздер!






KIND

Photo Gallery









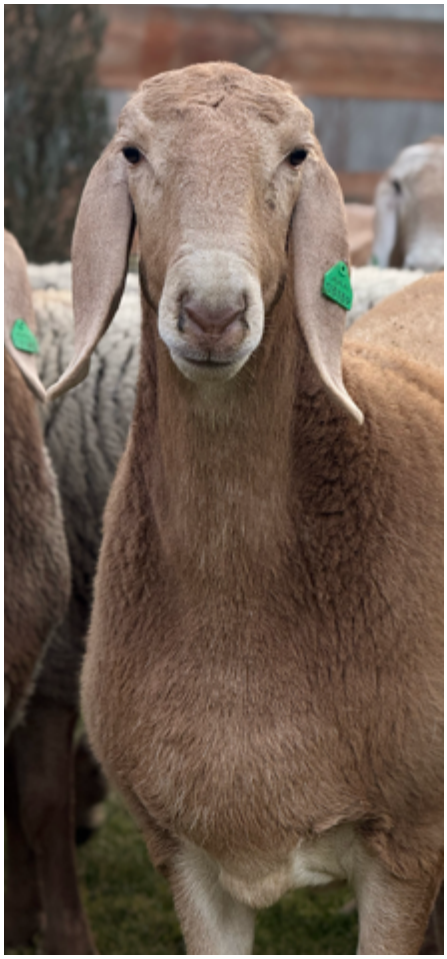




























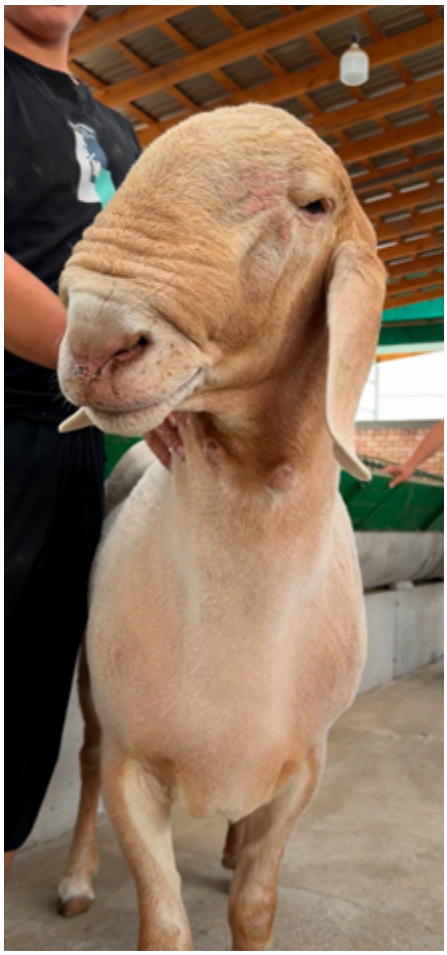

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